

Organizing for the Management of Educational Technologies

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Organizational Challenge

“..to develop a system that encourages teaching units to be innovative and able to respond quickly to changes in subject matter, student needs, and technology.” (pg. 181)

Basic Concepts

- Don't put too much on formal organizational structure; it can be dangerous
- People must be willing to work together
- Perfect organizational arrangements will not work if petty jealousies and conflicting ambitions get in the way.
- Technology should be driven by the respective function unit.

Managing Technology

- Centralized Technology Support
- Decentralized Services
- Combination of both Centralized and Decentralized Services Model

Centralized Technology Support

- Central Computing Organizations
- Human Support for the technology
- Technology-based teaching and learning
- Centralized support staff and technology specialists

Decentralized Services

- Instructor laptop and desktop machine
- Well-established “divisional” universities with large and powerful faculties
- Multiple centers of services with somewhat aligned activities

Centralized or Decentralized

- Centralized – there is no professional center to provide standards and career support and development for support staff and no strategic or regular funding to support technology-based initiatives.
- Decentralized – there is insufficient support close to faculty members.

Management Structures for Supporting Academic Technology

- Representative faculty members, some of whom should have extensive experience in using technology for teaching.
- A dean or two
- The director of the teaching and learning center.
- The librarian
- The person responsible for the technology infrastructure.

Looking Beyond

- Less and less development of whole courses by teams of specialists working with subject experts
- More and more development of small learning objects, from single diagrams to complex expert systems. This is a distributed concept.
- Faculty and students share their own teaching and learning through the “virtual environments”
- University, neighboring universities, and business partners share resources and services

Closing Thought

Technology makes up many different components—technology infrastructure and support infrastructure—there are many organization-units. All these sub-organizations are coordinate by the central technology organization. In addition, I believe that there will be less and less development of whole courses by teams of specialist working with subject experts, and more and more development of small learning objects, from single diagrams to complex expert systems.

Discussion

1. Educational technology support is better with centrally managed or de-centrally managed?
2. Technology support for teaching and learning is better handle at department level or institution level?
3. Institution provides standards and policies for education support. Do you agree with this idea?

References

- University of Calgary, Learning Commons, <http://www.ucalgary.ca>
- University of Alberta, Academic Technology for Learning, <http://www.atl.ualberta.ca>
- CSU, Center for Distributed Learning, <http://www.cdl.edu>)